

Challenges and Disparities Faced by LGBTQ+ Students in the Transition to College

Survey Evidence from the California High School Class of 2023

Christina Sun

With Alexandria Hurtt, Michal Kurlaender, Kairo Weber, and Baiyu Zhou

University of California, Davis

Note: This research was supported by the College Futures Foundation and conducted in partnership with the California Student Aid Commission. The authors are also grateful for ongoing support from the Stuart Foundation to the California Education Lab. The California Education Lab at the University of California, Davis and Policy Analysis for California Education are also thankful for research dissemination support from the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation. The findings and conclusions here are those of the authors alone and do not necessarily reflect the positions or policies of the funders or of the California Student Aid Commission.

Acknowledgements

- California Student Aid Commission
 - Marlene Garcia
 - Jessica Moldoff
 - Ryan Fuller
- California Department of Education
- California Education Lab
 - Elizabeth Friedmann
 - Sherrie Reed
 - Paco Martorell
 - Scott Carrell

Overview

This project is the first to utilize a large student survey to explore high school student experiences and postsecondary plans by a diverse set of gender identities and sexual orientations.

- Motivation
- Methodology
- Data
- Findings
- Discussion

Motivation

- The high school to college transition is crucial for young adults (Luh et al., 2023)
- Schools shape students' perceptions of college and future educational attainment (Lynn et al., 2010; Uwah et al., 2008)
- Existing research documents differences in outcomes among historically underserved groups
 - Limited evidence regarding LGBTQ+ students
 - Research tends to consider the community as a whole
- This study provides direct descriptive evidence on LGBTQ+ students' experiences before college, and examine subgroup differences within the community

Literature Review

- Gender and sexual minority students experience differences in outcomes compared to their cisgender, heterosexual peers
 - Academic performance, including college admission (Aragon et al., 2014; Feldman et al., 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021)
 - Mental health (Kirsch et al., 2015; Marshal et al., 2011)
- Transgender youth often face additional barriers to educational success, including bullying/harassment and genderist practices (Marine, 2017)
- Differential impact of COVID-19
 - Compounded difficult relationships between gender and sexual minority youth and rejecting parents (Fish et al., 2020)

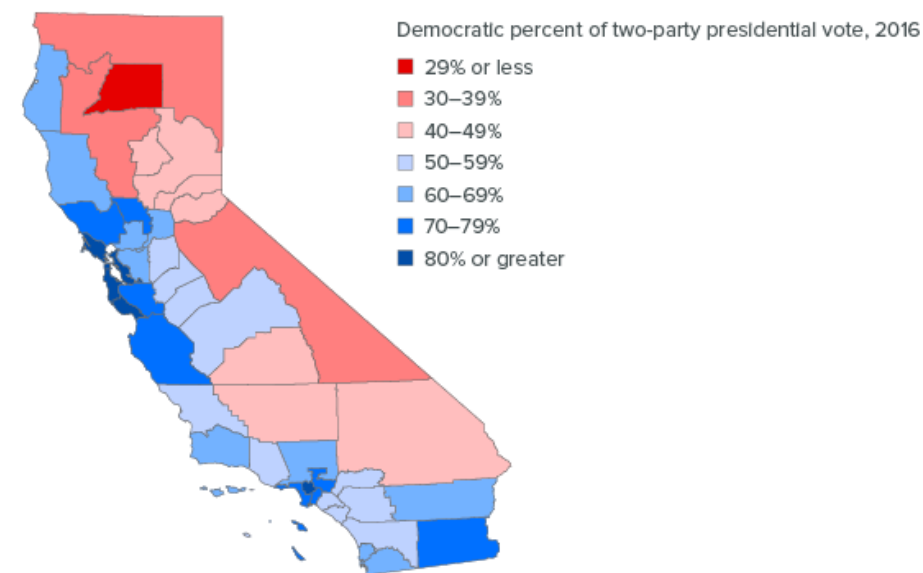
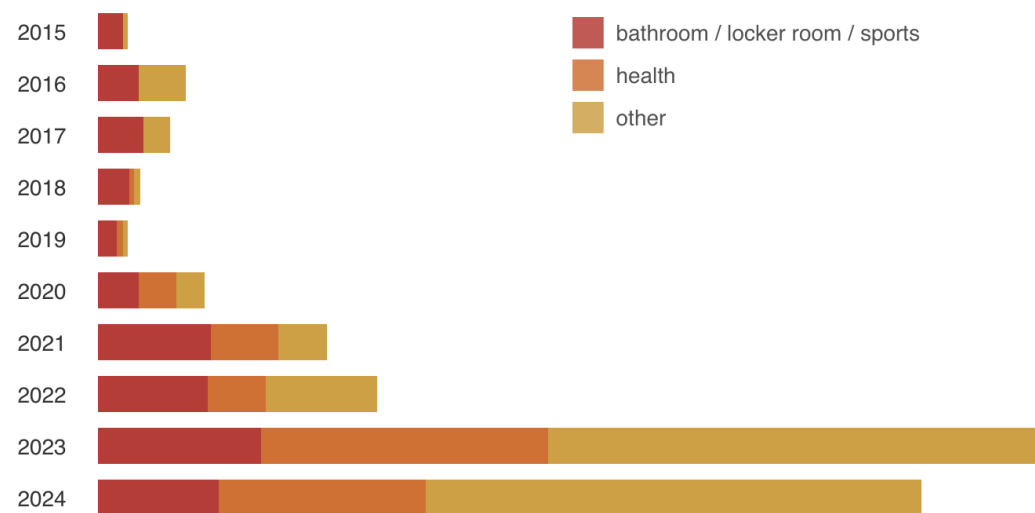
Institutional and Social Context

- COVID-19 Pandemic
 - Remote start to high school
 - Significant portion of high school was conducted online
- Policy changes in financial aid application submission
 - AB 469 (2021) mandates graduating high school seniors to complete a FAFSA or CADAA (with opt-out waivers)
 - Class of 2023 is first cohort

Institutional and Social Context

- Heightened visibility of and backlash against LGBTQ+ people

Number of anti-trans bills in the US



- Study conducted in California
 - Diverse demographics and political leanings
 - Rise of anti-trans hate groups like “Moms for Liberty”

Research Questions

- How do high school students today define their own gender identity and sexual orientation?
- Are there different patterns in experiences and aspirations among sexual and gender minority students?
- What are the challenges faced by sexual and gender minority students in the transition to college?

Contributions

- Use validated survey instruments to collect nuanced data on gender identity and sexual orientation from a large sample of high school seniors
 - Recent surveys tend to draw on a narrow sample of students, students predominantly enrolled in earlier grades, or data collected pre-pandemic (Austin et al., 2023; Horowitz & Graf, 2019; Kosciw et al., 2022; Reber & Smith, 2023; YouScience, 2023)
- Add to the growing literature on the academic and social experiences of LGBTQ+ students in high school and college (e.g., Austin et al., 2023; Feldman et al., 2023; Kosciw et al., 2022; Reber & Smith, 2023)
- Contribute to the broader literature on the transition to college by adding new evidence on the experiences of underserved students

Methodology

- Launched an internet-based survey in May 2023 in partnership with the California Student Aid Commission (CSAC)
- Distributed by email to all high school seniors in California that submitted a Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) or California Dream Act Application (CADAA) for the 2023-24 academic year
 - Response rate of 3.5%, yet the sample represents a diverse group of students from many different backgrounds and geographic regions throughout the state
 - Convenience sample but large
 - The survey's main components were questions that gather evidence on student experiences navigating the financial aid system
 - We included questions on social and academic experiences to provide broader and more diverse evidence on student life

Methodology

- Likert-scale questions
 - Students' high school experiences, college preparation and plans, concerns about college
- Demographic questions
- Open-ended questions
 - Perceived challenges and excitement about college

Sample Characteristics

	Survey Respondents		Statewide	
	N	Percent	N	Percent
Total	10,221	-	488936	-
Race/ethnicity				
American Indian/Alaskan Native/Pacific Islander	247	2.42	2349	0.48
Black/African American	559	5.47	23852	4.88
Hispanic/Latinx	4066	39.78	272323	55.70
Filipino	244	2.39	13231	2.71
Asian	1163	11.38	46278	9.47
Other	198	1.94	17435	3.57
White/Non-Hispanic	1553	15.19	103787	21.23
Not reported	2191	21.44	7576	1.55
Gender				
Cis woman	4503	44.06	Female	48
Cis man	2864	28.02	Male	51.5
Non-binary/Gender variant	418	4.09	Non-binary	< 0.5
Unsure/prefer not to say	191	1.87		
Not reported	2245	21.96		
Parent level of education				
Did not complete high school	1467	14.35		
High school diploma	1708	16.71		
Some college, no college degree	1023	10.01		
Associate degree	474	4.64		
Bachelor's degree	1394	13.64		
Graduate/professional degree	1485	14.53		
Don't know	447	4.37		
Not reported	2223	21.75		

Compared to all 12th graders enrolled in California public high schools, our sample:

- Overrepresents American Indian/Alaskan Native/Pacific Islanders
- Overrepresents Black/African Americans
- Underrepresents Hispanic/Latinx students

The state only includes 3 categories for the gender identity information it collects:

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary

Data

- The raw sample includes a total of 10,221 complete responses
- Our sample includes around 9,230 college-bound HS seniors
 - 7,522 who reported gender identity
 - 7,481 who reported sexual orientation
- Our sample includes 1,828 LGBTQ+ students (excluding *Prefer Not to Say*)
 - 417 who we classify as being non-cisgender
 - 1,782 who we classify as being non-heterosexual

Classification of Gender Identity

- “Two-Step” Approach recommended by the Williams Institute

Q78

What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

☐ Female

☐ Male

Q80

What is your current gender identity?

☐ Woman

☐ Man

☐ Non-binary

☐ Prefer not to say

☐ Other (please feel free to specify)

Classification of Gender Identity

Assigned Sex at Birth	Current Gender	Gender Identity Classification	
Male	Man	Cisgender Man	
Female	Woman	Cisgender Woman	
Male	Woman	(Binary) Transgender Woman	(Binary) Transgender
Female	Man	(Binary) Transgender Man	
Any	Non-binary/Self Describe/Questioning	Non-binary/Gender Diverse/Questioning	
Any	Prefer not to say/Attack helicopters	Prefer not to say	

Classification of Sexual Orientation

- Adapted from recommendations by the Williams Institute to allow for a broader range of expressions

Q82

What is your sexual orientation?

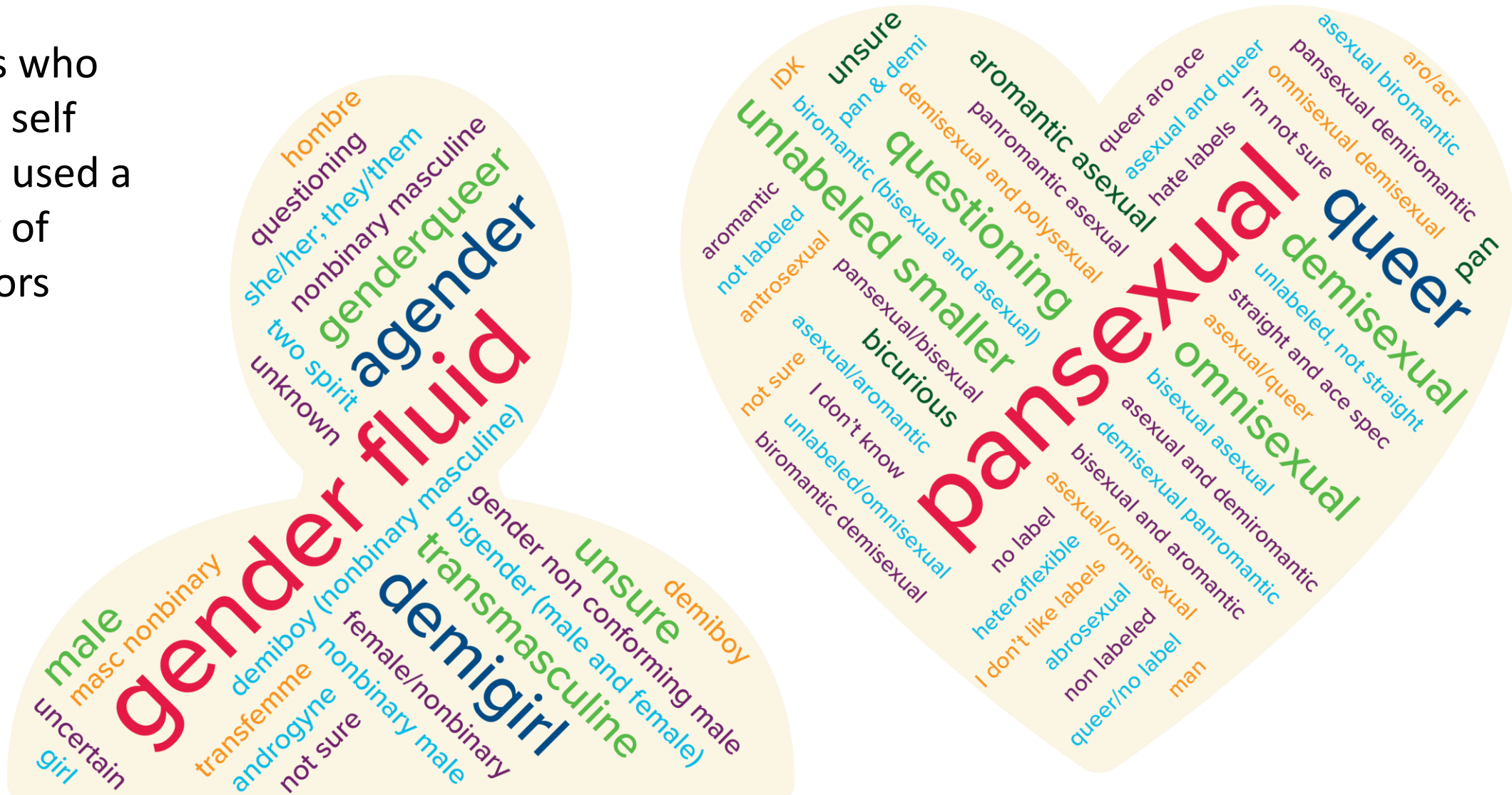
- ☐ Lesbian or Gay
- ☐ Straight (not gay or lesbian)
- ☐ Bisexual
- ☐ Asexual
- ☐ Other (feel free to specify)
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Classification of Sexual Orientation

Sexual Orientation	Sexual Orientation Classification
Lesbian or Gay	Gay/Lesbian
Straight (not gay or lesbian)	Heterosexual
Bisexual/Self described pansexual	Bisexual/Pansexual
Asexual/Self described asexual/demisexual/aromantic	Asexual/Demisexual/Aromantic
Self described other non-heterosexual orientations/questioning	Other/Queer/Questioning
Prefer not to say/Attack helicopters	Prefer not to say

Gender and Sexuality Diversity

Students who chose to self describe used a diversity of descriptors

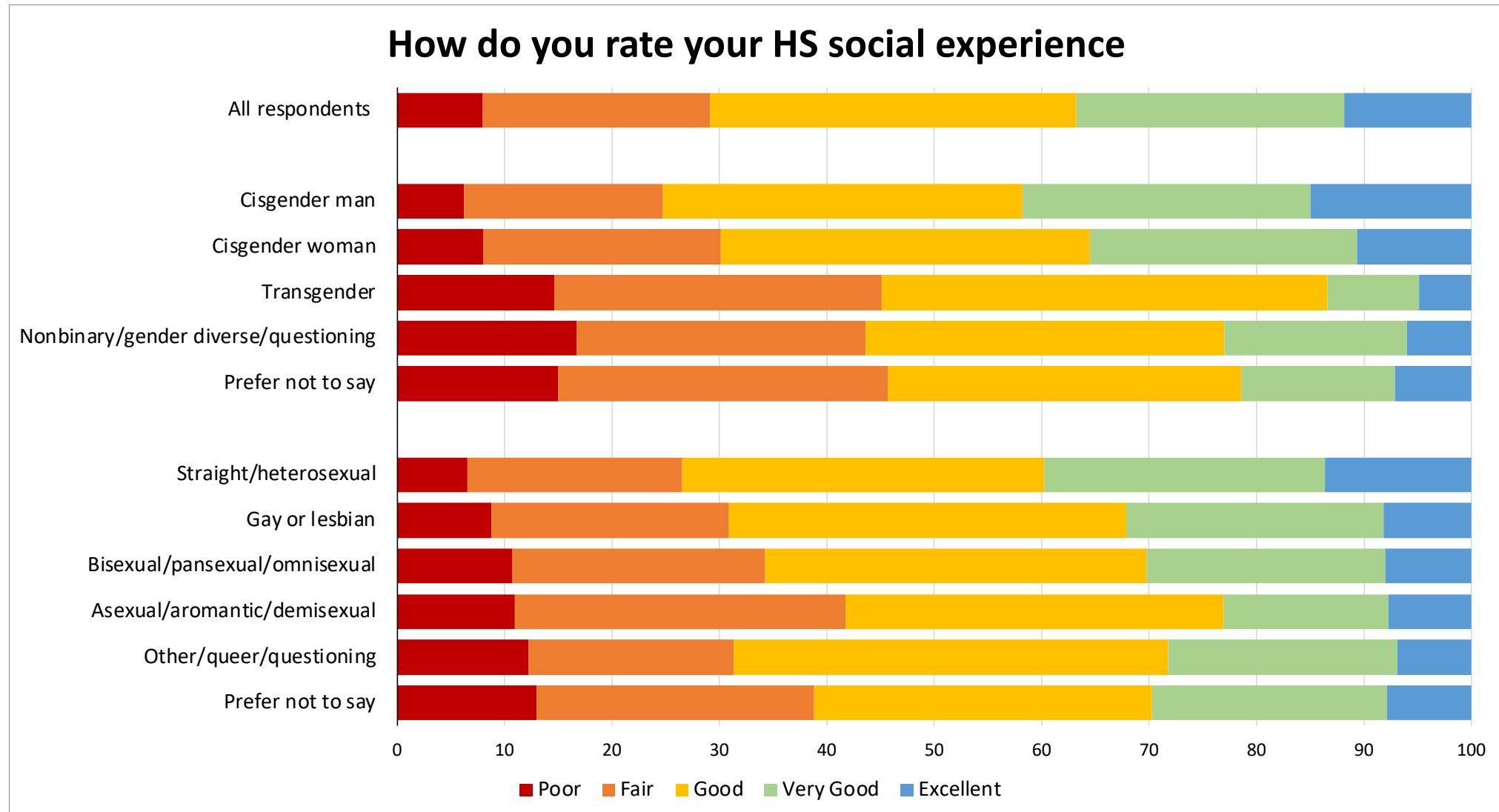


Limitations/Caveats

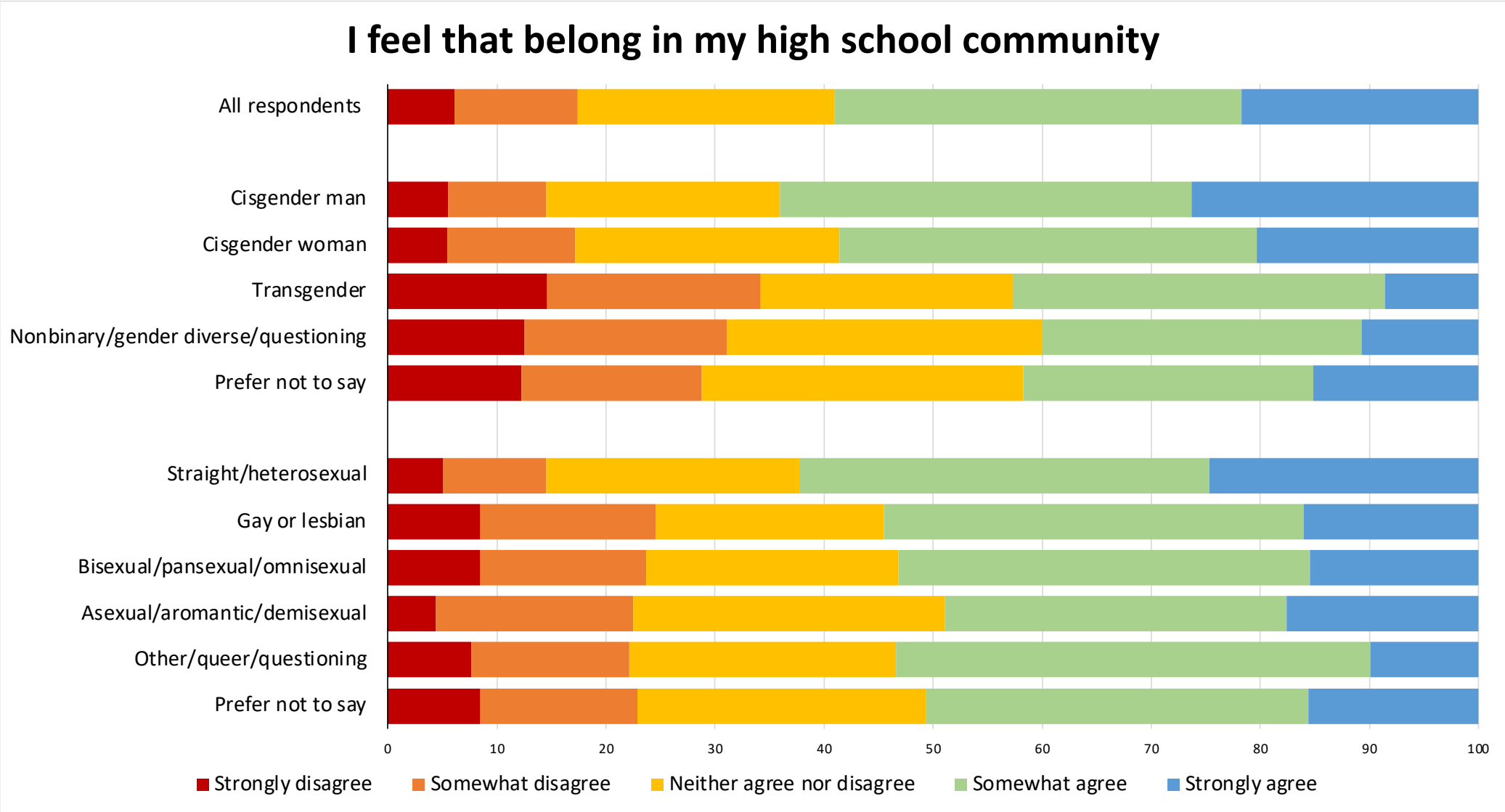
- We are not able to do subgroup analysis for every single identity
- Have to combine some gender/sexual orientation categories due to cell size issues
- We follow a particular classification method and definitions for gender/sexual identities
 - E.g. Is transgender an umbrella term or a specific subgroup?

High School Experience

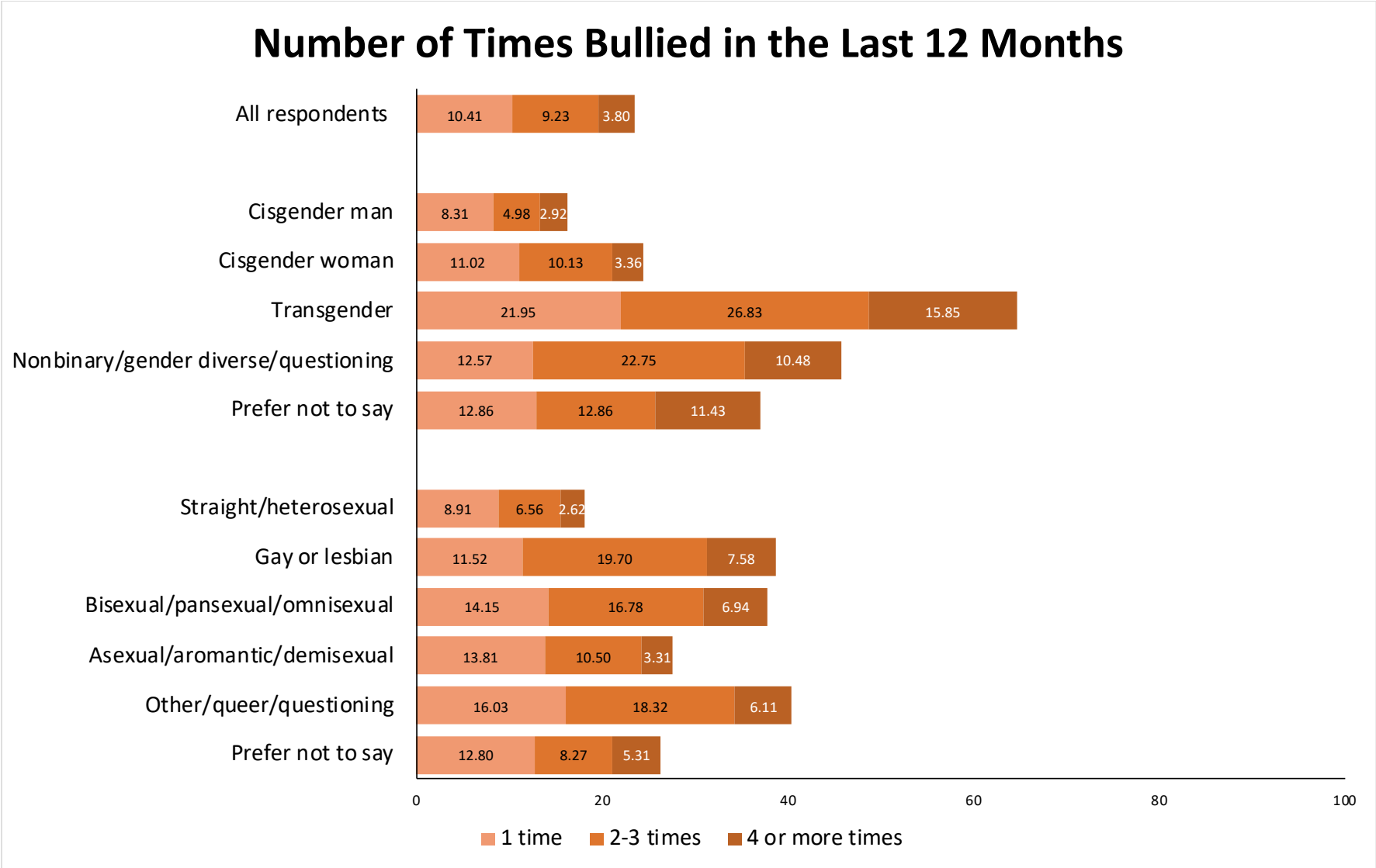
Self Rating of High School Social Experience



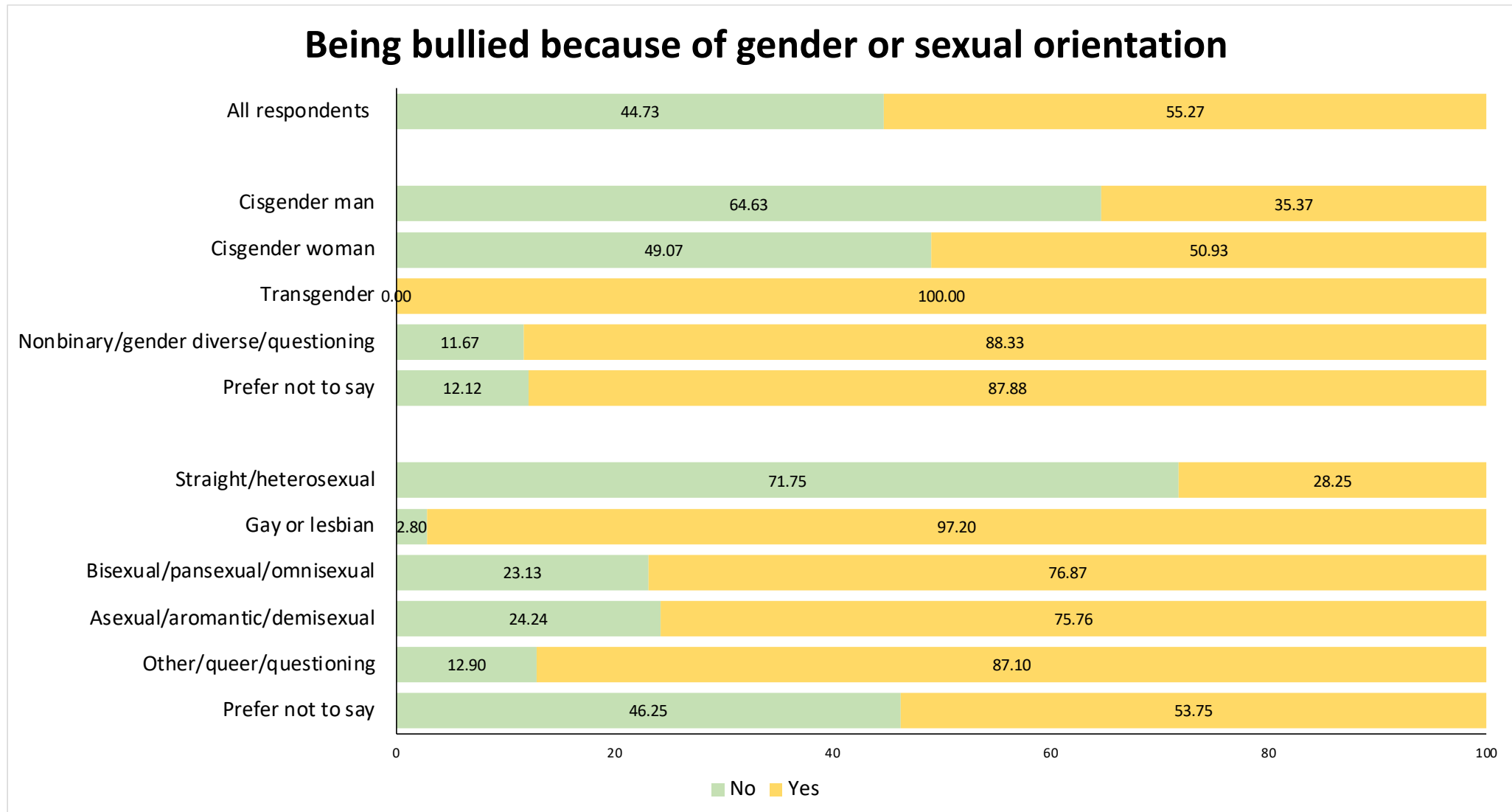
Belonging in High School



Experienced Bullying

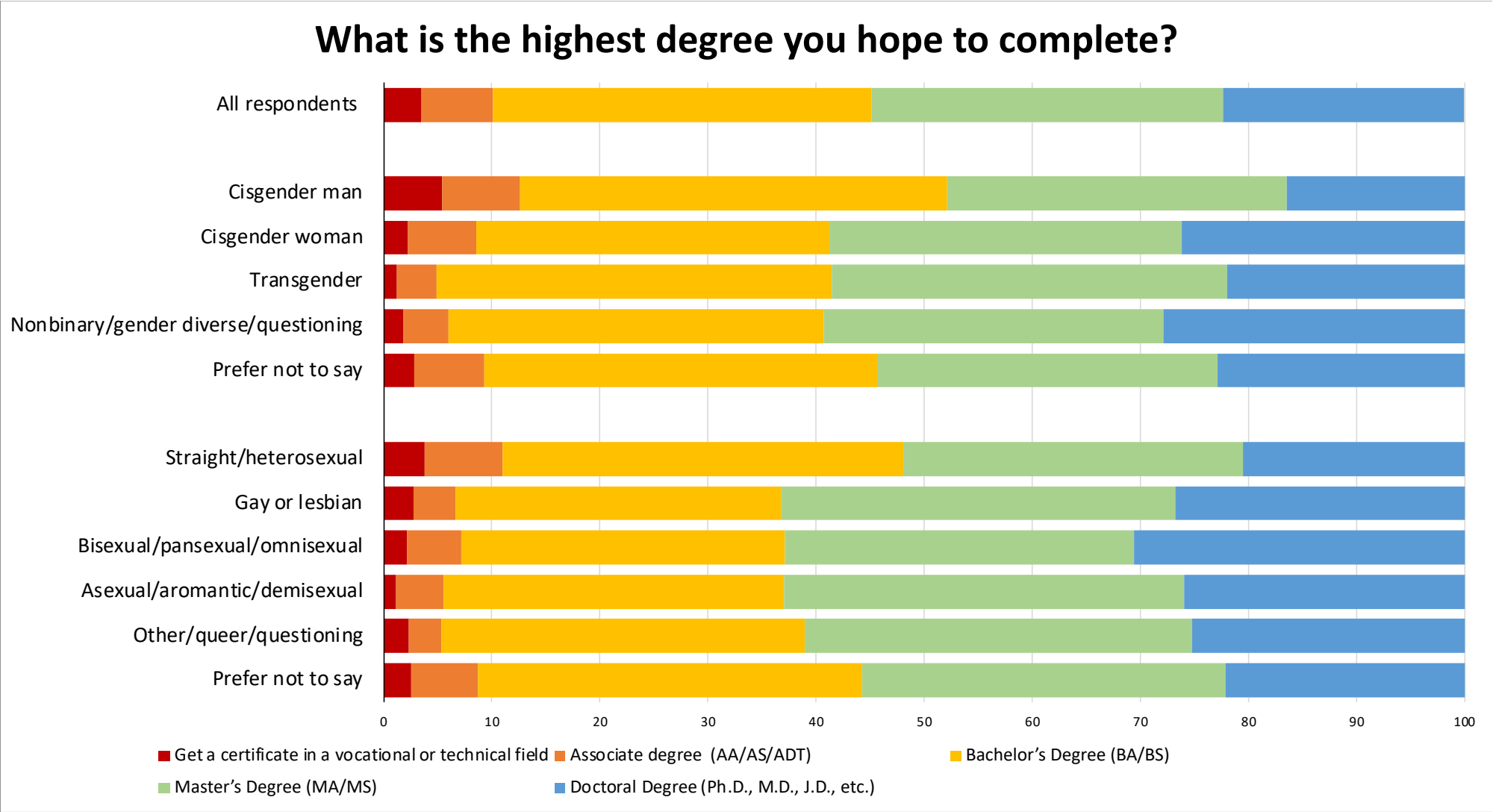


Reasons Bullied: Gender and Sexual Orientation

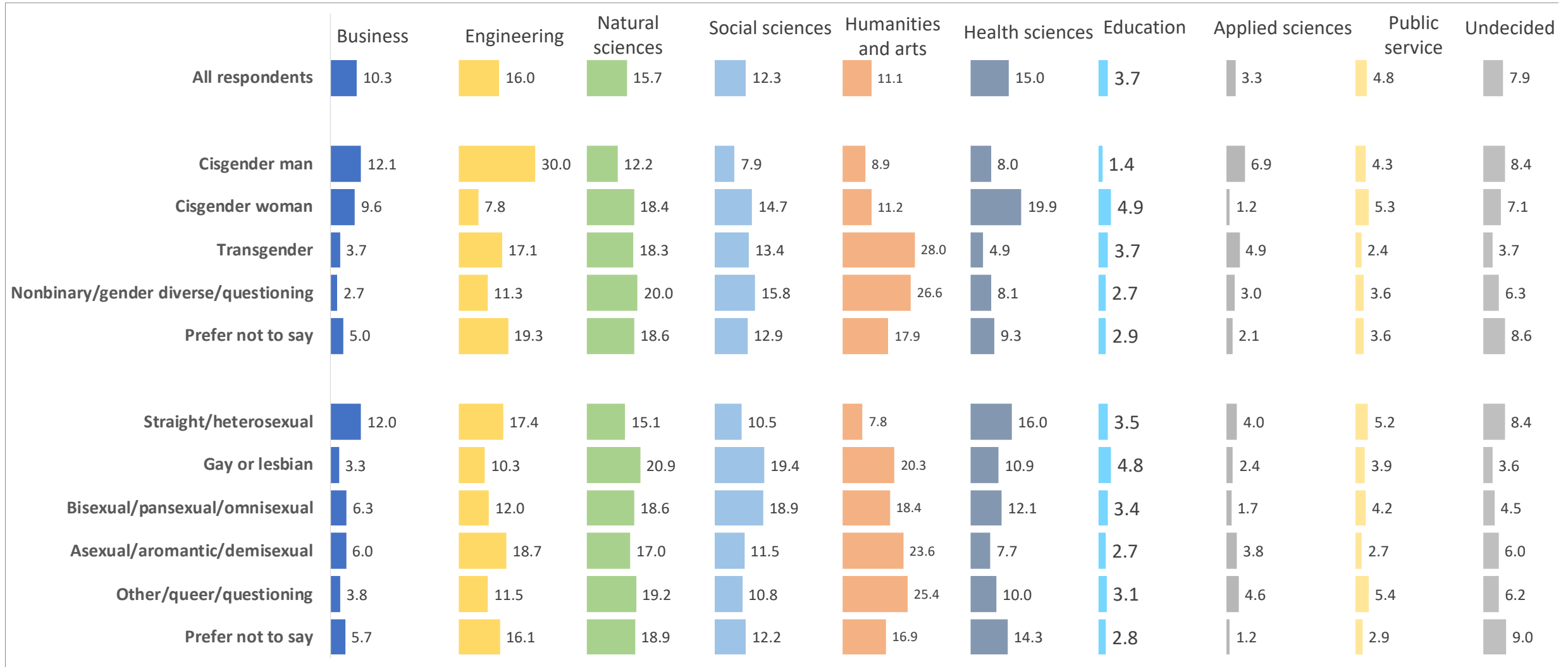


College Plans

Educational Aspirations

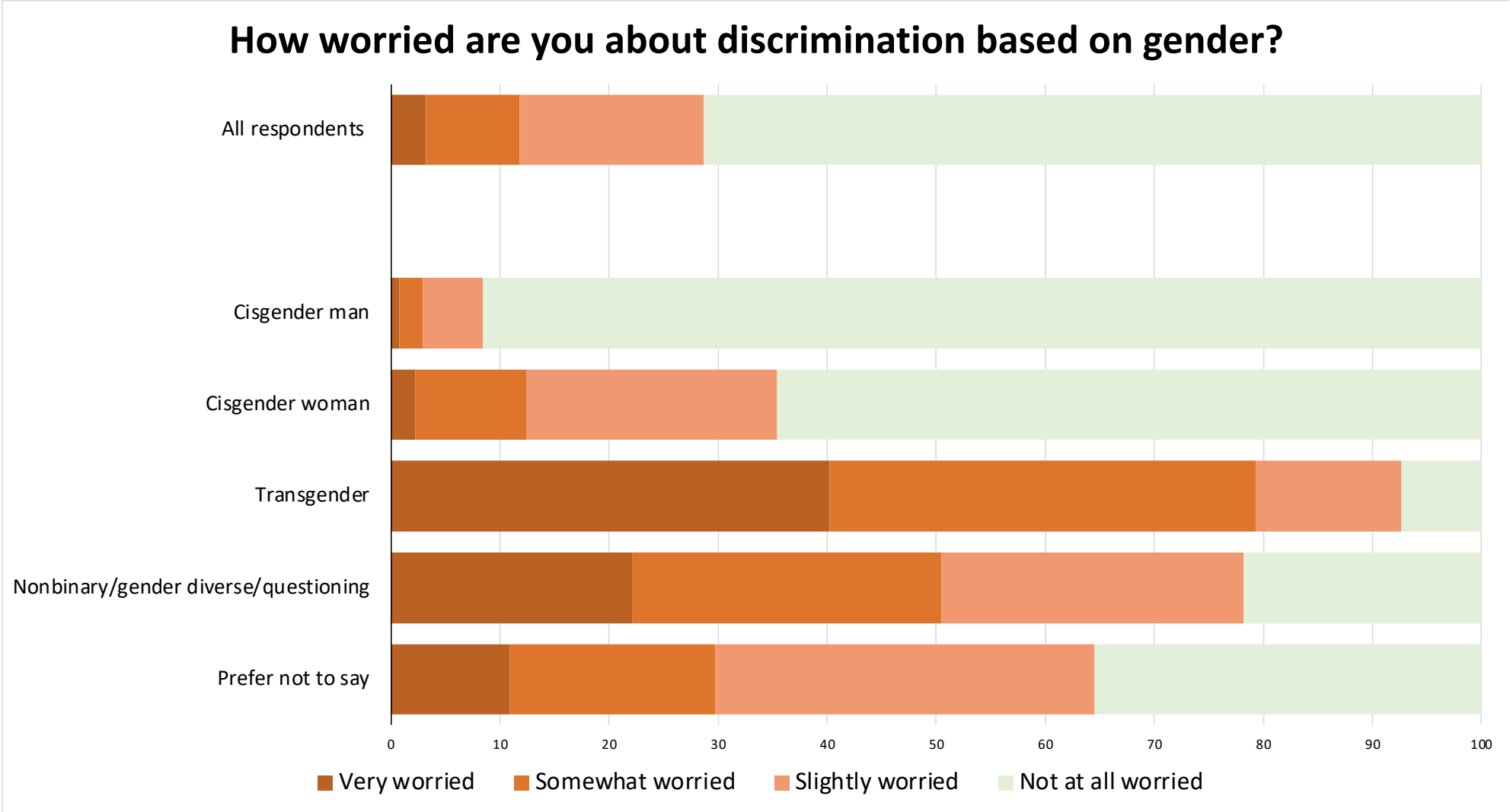


College Major Plans

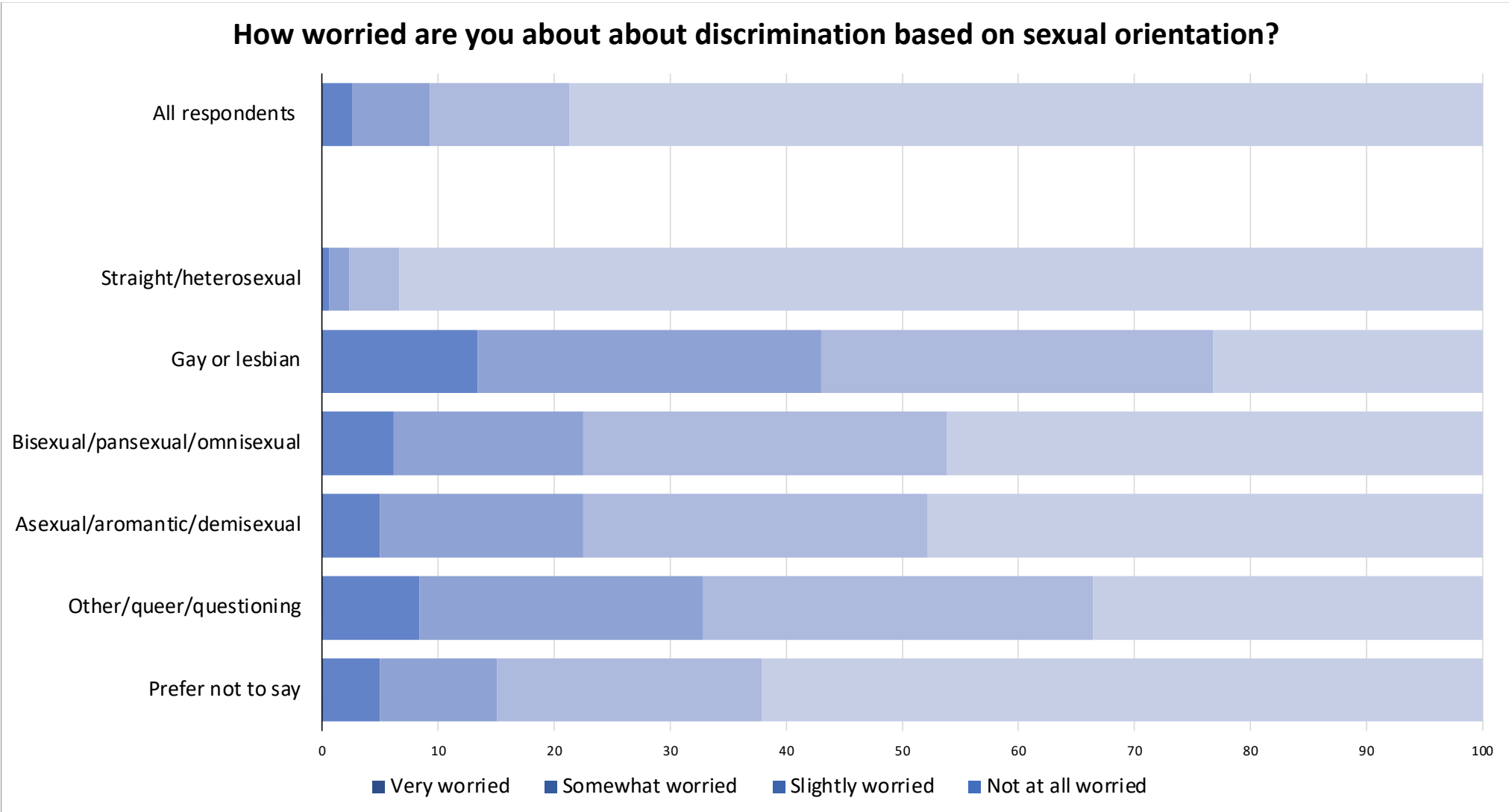


Worries About College

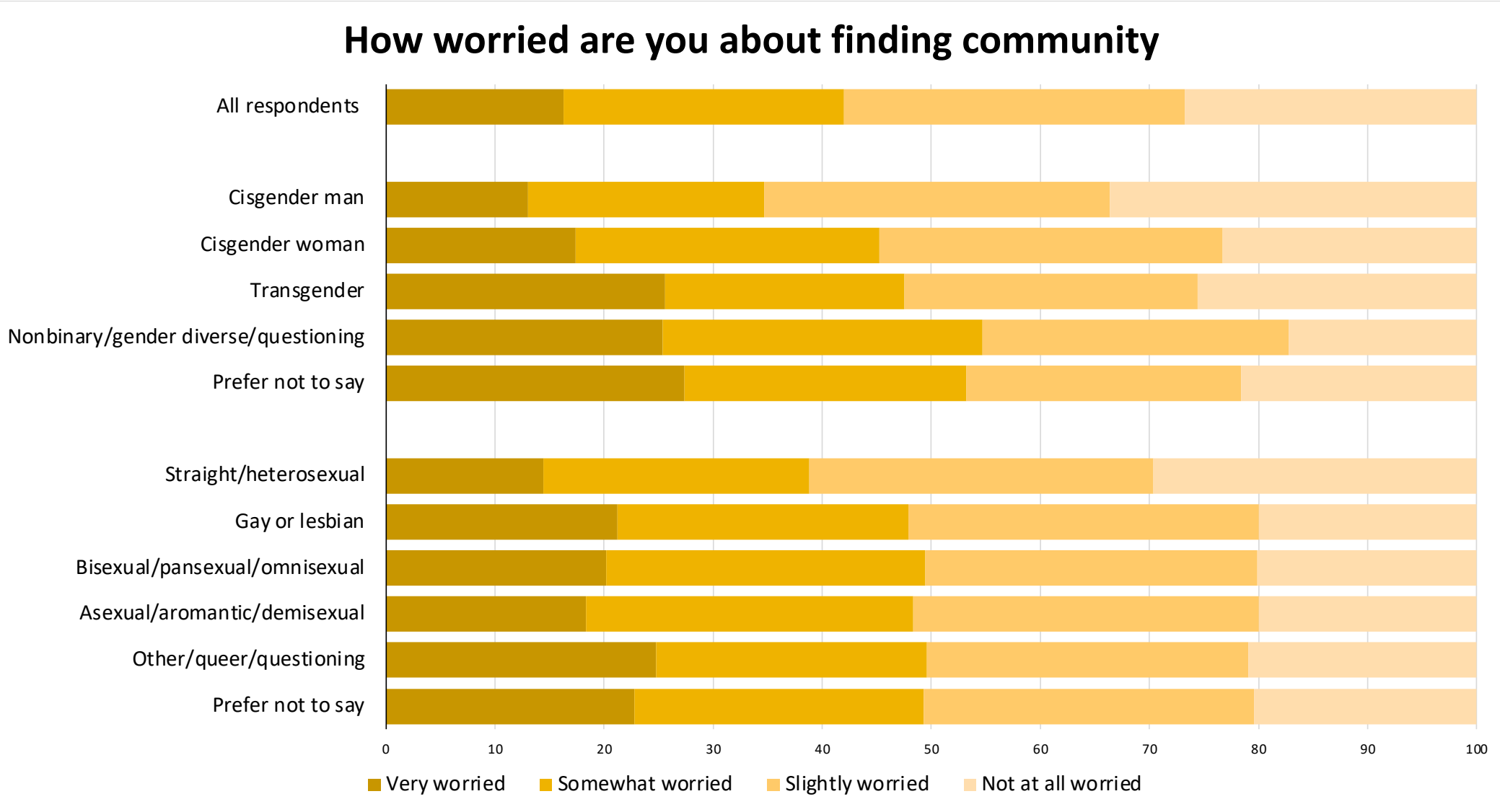
Worried about Discrimination on Gender



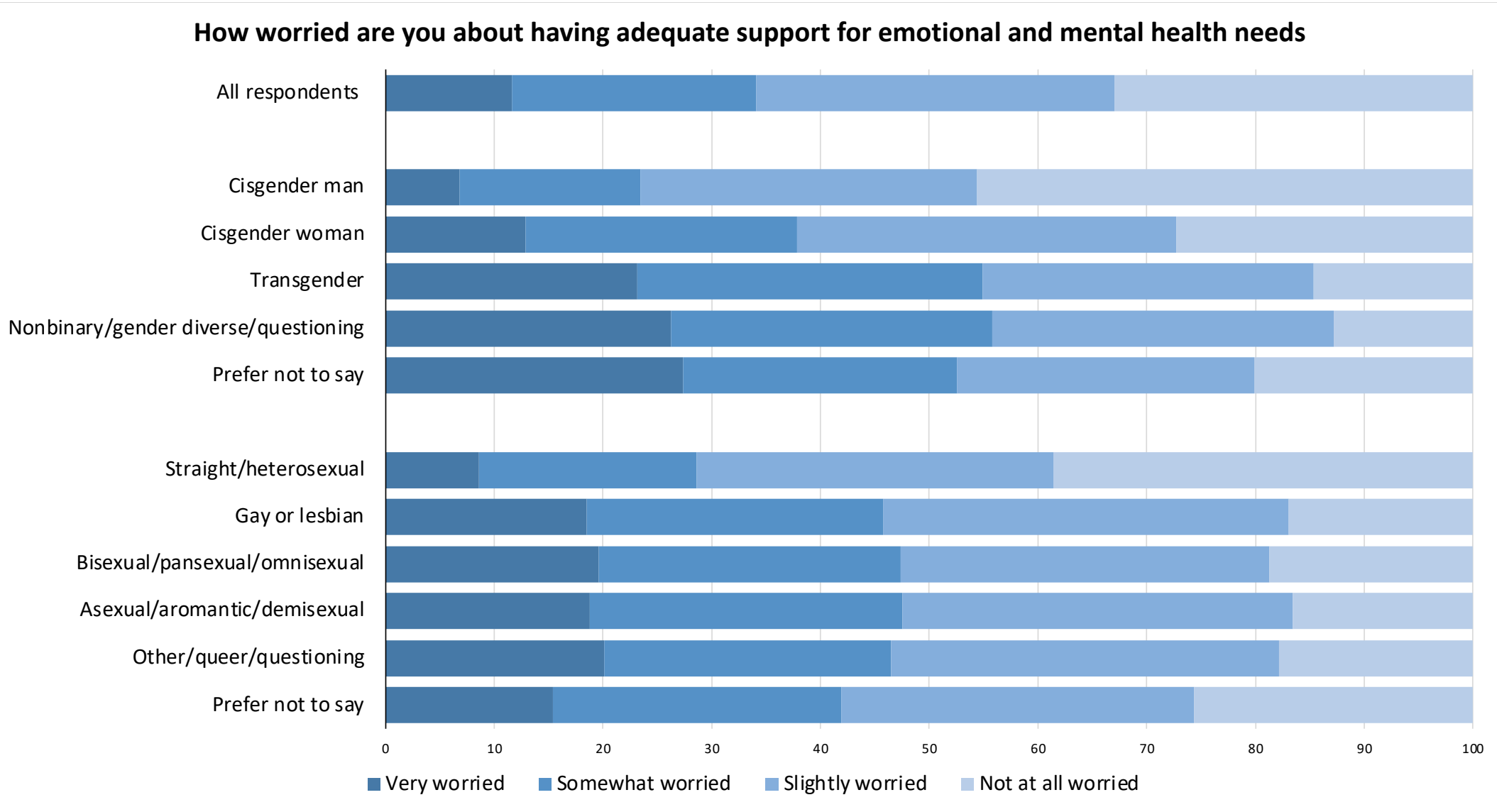
Worried about Discrimination on Sexual orientation



Worried about Finding Community



Worried about Adequate Support



Qualitative Analysis

Qualitative Analysis of Student Voices

- The top themes expressed by gender diverse students for challenges in college are
 - Academics
 - Balancing and managing time
 - Only 10 listed discrimination
- The top themes for excitements:
 - Learning and academics
 - Finding community
 - Gaining independence

What Gender Diverse Students Say

Content Warning: Suicide

Fears of Discrimination

“Transphobia”

“Political and social conflicts. I could die from hate crimes, but it's more likely that I end up killing myself. I struggle a lot with being trans and if not able to transition in college, I'm going to give up on everything. The political climate in Taiwan could reach a tipping point while I am in college. If that happens, I am likely going to drop everything to help my family.”

“lack of community due to discrimination”

“I think the biggest challenge will be standing up for myself.”

“Coming out to people around me.”

Excitement about College

“Being able to build a community for myself where I truly feel that I belong.”

“I'm excited to be myself. I live in a house of five. I'm the youngest of my three siblings, meaning I've had to share a room with my 23 year old sister since I was born. I've never had privacy and I never felt like I could be myself. To use broad terms, I could never properly express myself as a gay, trans teen. I can't wait to make new friends and enjoy my new found independence.

“I'm [excited] about moving from home and working to establish my independence.”

“Getting out of my small area bubble and living on my own as my own person.”

“Finding likeminded people with similar interests and finding people who have the same sexual orientation”

Creating a healthy social circle, increased responsibility and freedom, and learning about specific subjects that interest me.

Questions and Comments

Thank you!

- California Education Lab
 - Elizabeth Friedmann
 - Sherrie Reed
 - Paco Martorell
 - Scott Carrell

- California Student Aid Commission
 - Marlene Garcia
 - Jessica Moldoff
 - Ryan Fuller

This research was supported by the College Futures Foundation and conducted in partnership with the California Student Aid Commission. The authors are also grateful for ongoing support from the Stuart Foundation to the California Education Lab. The California Education Lab at the University of California, Davis and Policy Analysis for California Education are also thankful for research dissemination support from the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation. The findings and conclusions here are those of the authors alone and do not necessarily reflect the positions or policies of the funders or of the California Student Aid Commission.